

MZURI ORGANICS

Gare Holdings Limited | Regenerative Agriculture & Circular Bioeconomy

CALL FOR APPLICATIONS GRADUATE RESEARCH ASSISTANT

FungaFrass Bio (FF-Bio) Project | FS4Africa Open Call 1

Position Title	Part-Time Graduate Research Assistant	Project	FungaFrass Bio (FF-Bio): Scaling Fungus-Rich Biofertilizers for Safer and Resilient Informal Vegetable Value Chains
Organisation	Mzuri Organics (Gare Holdings Ltd)	Project Counties	Kakamega, Bungoma, Siaya, Uasin Gishu and Vihiga
Duration	Eight (8) months, part-time: 10 days per month	Stipend	Modest monthly stipend, subject to applicable statutory deductions plus field facilitation available for approved project travel and field activities
Reporting Line	Project Coordinator, with technical supervision from the M&E Lead and relevant technical specialists	Target Level	Master's-level student/candidate or recent postgraduate candidate
Preferred Fields	Soil Science, Agronomy, Horticulture, Environmental Science, Plant Pathology, Agricultural Extension, Food Safety, Microbiology, or related disciplines	Deadline	25 June 2026, 5:00 PM EAT
Expected Start Date	To be confirmed after selection and contracting	No. of Positions	One (1)

1. Background

Mzuri Organics (Gare Holdings Limited) is implementing the FungaFrass Bio (FF-Bio) sub-project under FS4Africa Open Call 1 funded by the European Union. FF-Bio is a multi-county demonstration and field evaluation initiative focused on scaling fungus-rich biofertilizer systems for safer, more resilient informal vegetable value chains in Western Kenya.

The project will establish participatory demonstration gardens across the five target counties and will generate field evidence on bio-based soil health approaches, pesticide-use reduction, crop performance, soil health, farmer economics, adoption, residue compliance and food safety outcomes.

2. Purpose of the Opportunity

Mzuri Organics seeks to engage one Graduate Research Assistant on a part-time, project-based basis to support field research, monitoring, data management, sample tracking, farmer engagement, evidence generation, and research dissemination under the FF-Bio project.

The opportunity is suitable for a Master's-level student or recent postgraduate candidate seeking practical research experience in soil health, regenerative agriculture, food safety, agronomy, horticulture, environmental science, microbiology, plant pathology, or a related discipline. The selected candidate will be engaged for 10 days per month over an 8-month period.

A key final ambition of the project is to develop a science-backed manuscript for submission to a peer-reviewed scientific journal. The Graduate Research Assistant will therefore support literature review, evidence synthesis, preparation of tables and figures, and manuscript drafting under the guidance of the project's technical team.

3. Key Responsibilities

The Graduate Research Assistant will support the FF-Bio technical and implementation team in the following areas:

Field Research and Site Support

- Support implementation and monitoring of FF-Bio field research activities across selected demonstration gardens and farmer groups.
- Assist with field visits, farmer engagement, farmer training sessions, field days, stakeholder demonstrations, and site-level follow-up.
- Support verification of plot layout, treatment allocation, crop management records, and compliance with approved project protocols.

Data Collection, Data Quality and Documentation

- Assist with baseline, midline, and endline data collection, including farmer interviews, field observations, crop monitoring, input-use records, pesticide-use records, yield data and simple economic data.
- Carry out routine data checks, flag missing or inconsistent entries, and support cleaning, coding, summarising and organisation of datasets.
- Maintain organised digital and physical evidence folders, including field notes, attendance sheets, photographs, sample logs, monitoring sheets and reports.

Soil, Crop and Residue Sampling Support

- Support soil and crop sample planning, labelling, chain-of-custody documentation, transportation coordination, laboratory submission tracking and results follow-up.
- Ensure sampling records capture date, county/site, farmer ID, plot treatment, sample type and relevant field observations.
- Support monitoring of agronomic indicators such as germination, crop establishment, plant vigour, pest and disease observations, marketable yield, non-marketable yield and produce quality.

Scientific Publication and Knowledge Dissemination

- Conduct targeted literature reviews on fungus-rich biofertilizers, soil biological health, Integrated Pest Management, pesticide-use reduction, food safety, MRL compliance and informal vegetable production systems.
- Assist in organising, summarising and interpreting FF-Bio field, soil, crop, pesticide-use, yield, economic and adoption datasets for scientific reporting.
- Contribute to preparation of tables, graphs, references, technical summaries and draft manuscript sections for a peer-reviewed journal submission.
- Support development of project learning briefs, conference abstracts, posters, technical notes and evidence summaries where required.
- Observe responsible scientific writing standards, including plagiarism avoidance, proper citation, confidentiality, data integrity and responsible acknowledgement of contributors.

Reporting and Coordination

- Prepare concise monthly activity reports and timesheets showing tasks completed, sites visited, data collected, issues encountered, pending actions and next steps.
- Participate in technical review meetings and support preparation of project reports and dissemination products.
- Comply with FF-Bio ethics, informed consent, confidentiality, data protection, respectful farmer engagement and safe field conduct requirements at all times.

4. Required Qualifications and Competencies

- Ongoing or recently completed Master's degree in Soil Science, Agronomy, Horticulture, Environmental Science, Plant Pathology, Agricultural Extension, Food Safety, Microbiology, Crop Science, Food Systems, Environmental Biology, or a closely related field.
- Strong interest in regenerative agriculture, soil health, biofertilizers, pesticide-use reduction, IPM, food safety, smallholder farming systems and informal vegetable value chains.
- Good understanding of research methods, data collection, data cleaning, literature review, scientific reporting and field documentation.
- Ability to work in field conditions across rural project sites and interact respectfully with farmers, farmer groups, county actors and project partners.
- Working knowledge of spreadsheet-based data management. Experience with KoboToolbox/ODK, Excel, R, Python, SPSS, STATA or similar tools will be an added advantage.
- Good writing skills in English; ability to communicate in Kiswahili and relevant local languages used in the project counties will be an added advantage.
- High integrity, attention to detail, confidentiality and willingness to follow approved research protocols and consent procedures.
- Ability and willingness to travel within the project counties when required and to work with a multi-disciplinary team.

6. Added Advantage

- Prior experience in academic writing, scientific publication, manuscript preparation, journal submission processes, thesis-to-paper conversion, conference abstracts, posters or technical research reporting.
- Evidence of contribution to a published paper, manuscript draft, thesis chapter, conference paper, poster, policy brief, technical report, research report or other scientific writing output.
- Experience in soil sampling, crop monitoring, pesticide-use surveys, vegetable production trials, residue studies, agronomic field trials, RCBD designs or farmer participatory research.
- Understanding of soil biology, microbial indicators, compost/frass-based inputs, plant nutrition, plant health, pesticide residue testing or food safety testing.

7. Application Requirements

Applicants should submit the following documents as one combined PDF where possible:

- Cover letter explaining interest in the FF-Bio Graduate Research Assistant opportunity and relevant experience.

- Updated CV of not more than 3 pages, including academic background, field research experience, software/data skills and publications or writing outputs where applicable.
- Brief concept note or statement of research interest, not more than 2 pages, showing how the applicant's academic interests align with FF-Bio.
- Academic transcripts, certificates or proof of enrolment/completion at Master's level.
- Link to a writing sample, such as a thesis chapter, published paper, manuscript draft, conference paper, research report, policy brief, technical report or literature review.
- Names and contacts of two referees, preferably one academic and one professional or field supervisor.
- Statement confirming availability for the 8-month part-time engagement, 10 days per month, and field travel within the project counties.

8. How to Apply

Interested applicants should submit their application package by email with the subject line: Application - FF-Bio Graduate Research Assistant - [Applicant Name].

Send applications to: hr@mzuriorganics.co.ke; Cc: allan@mzuriorganics.co.ke

Application deadline: 25 June 2026, 5:00 PM EAT.

Late, incomplete, or incorrectly titled applications may not be considered. Only shortlisted candidates will be contacted.

9. Equal Opportunity, Ethics and Data Protection

Mzuri Organics is committed to equal opportunity, inclusion, ethical field research, confidentiality and responsible data handling. The selected Graduate Research Assistant will be required to comply with FF-Bio consent protocols, data protection requirements, field conduct standards and confidentiality obligations. Women and youth candidates who meet the requirements are encouraged to apply.

10. Important Publication and Authorship Note

Contribution to the scientific manuscript does not automatically guarantee lead authorship. Authorship and acknowledgements will be determined based on substantive intellectual contribution, data contribution, writing contribution, project ownership, ethical requirements and the publication policy agreed by Mzuri Organics and the technical team. No project data may be published, shared externally or submitted independently without prior written approval from Mzuri Organics.

Mzuri Organics | Soil Health • Food Safety • Regenerative Agriculture • Circular Bioeconomy